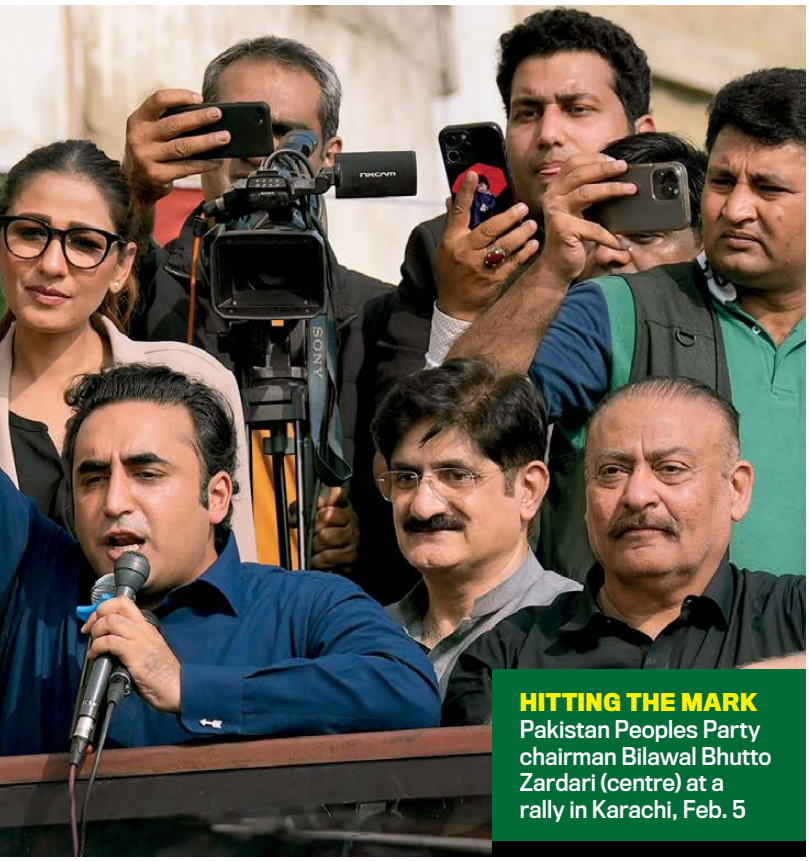
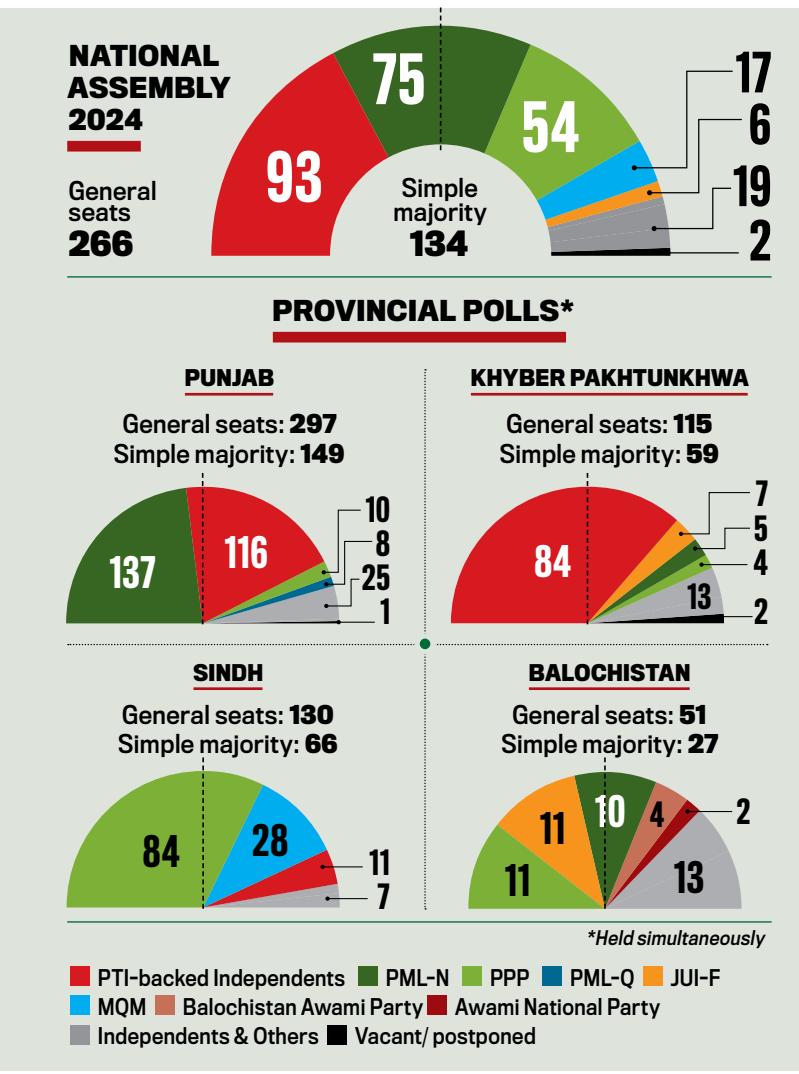
AP



HITTING THE MARK
Pakistan Peoples Party chairman Bilawal Bhutto Zardari (centre) at a rally in Karachi, Feb. 5

sentences running for up to 14 years in three back-to-back convictions, two of them slapped on him a week before the polls. Meanwhile, the Establishment pretty much rehabilitated Nawaz Sharif, who was ousted as prime minister in 2017, the fourth year of his third term, and has returned after spending much of the past six years in disgrace, including a four-year exile abroad. His past criminal convictions and misdemeanours, including his run-ins with the army brass, were pardoned by the courts, apparently to enable the army to politically checkmate Imran. The army was further angered by the mini insurrection that Imran's backers engineered, including mobs attacking its Rawalpindi HQ and also burning down the residence of its Lahore corps commander in May 2023. The new army chief, Gen. Asim Munir, ordered a statewide crackdown on all those involved in the violence.

In the run-up to the general election, the



The army had already indicated a preference for Shehbaz over Nawaz, who was prone to take a more independent path

Election Commission of Pakistan (ECP) banned the PTI from contesting as a party and froze its party symbol (the bat) for not adhering to rules stipulating intra-party polls. Yet despite Imran being lodged in jail, he and his supporters pulled off a good showing that surprised even the Establishment. Those affiliated with Imran's PTI, forced to fight as Independents, won 93 out of the 265 general seats contested in the National Assembly. (Election to one seat was deferred.) Though well short of the minimum 134 required for a majority, its share of seats was the largest among all parties. Sharif's PML-N won only 75 seats. The Bilawal Bhutto-led PPP came in third, with 54 seats, and the MQM-P stood fourth with 17, with the rest of the seats going to over a dozen smaller parties. The PTI announced it will go to the courts to challenge the results in 80-odd